



can speech be free?

A look at the discussions happening about free speech, and whether it's possible for Twitter to truly have that under Elon Musk

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Everyone supports free speech! Everyone! Their own speech that is. Supporting the free speech rights of those you dislike is a lot harder. Many will pretend to do it, but then shout them down, mock them or just ignore them anyway. And this isn't a left or right problem, or even a centrist problem. This isn't a political problem, even though people are quick to make it that. They will mock the woke-left, or call the other side right-wing nut jobs (RWNJs), the term Nazi gets thrown about often, as does fascist, and Hitler appears even faster than Godwin's Law could ever predict.

This is the state of supposed communication and conversations happening on the internet. What's

worse, kids who have grown up only talking like that online, and being exposed to this so-called "free speech" online where identities can be hidden easily, are now having real life conversations like this offline, and it's leading to fights, riots and worse. This is a global problem that no one is immune from.

In the midst of all that, when a billionaire buys a social media platform as diverse as Twitter and takes it private, citing the need for even freer speech, the whole world loses it. But why?

THE FREE SPEECH DEBATE

At its core, making totalitarian statements such as "free speech is an inalienable right", is a perfectly acceptable stance. It's easy for me to stand up and say I demand my right to say

what I please, even if it offends others, because others have that same right to try and offend me back. "Sticks and stones may break my bones, but names will never hurt me!"

And so in an ideal world you allow free speech, and allow people to do and say as they please. That's Elon Musk's argument in a nutshell.

And then you scratch the surface and find that there are some big flaws in that thinking.

Does this mean that one could do whatever is the equivalent of yelling fire in a crowded theatre? For those of you who aren't familiar with the saying, it was popularised when a US supreme court judge used it in a free speech case in 1917. It had nothing to do with anyone actually yelling fire in a theatre. However, there had been precedent set when in many different instances, falsely shouting "fire" had actually claimed the lives of people after a stampede started. In one particularly gruesome case in 1913, during a Christmas party organised for the children of striking miners, someone yelled fire and caused a stampede and 73 people died, most of them little children who'd come to get their Christmas gifts! Currently, free speech in the US would actually allow people to yell fire in a crowded building, but it would not be legal in many other countries that don't put free speech on a pedestal.

This is also perhaps why the US is the home of conspiracy theories. Because everyone is entitled to say whatever they want about any topic, whether true or false, and be protected by the law. Slander and libel laws exist of course, so there's some protection for people, but by and large it's a free for all. The hope is that the truth shall prevail, because those who know the truth will use their protected free speech rights to argue against those who are lying. Much better to let everyone speak rather than allow governments or organisations to censor dissenting voices.

And who can argue against that, right? The families of 73 killed in the false fire panic certainly would. Who